

had not witnessed earlier Indian stations, which were built for practical use.

Smaller stations of the time could usually be described as shanties surrounded by small huts for railways staff. Larger stations boasted of added benefits of separate rooms for men and women, space for bedding on the floor, and washrooms. Waiting rooms, when provided, were used by engineers and railway officials who required overnight lodging while on duty and did not offer much comfort to passengers. In fact, “dreary” Wadi was slightly grander as it had a refreshment room, built mainly because of its location on the junction of the key Madras–Bombay line.

The original Byculla and Howrah stations are examples of such spartan structures. Today’s grand Howrah station building was little more than a singular booking window with a small line for dock platforms that were used for freight when the first train began its journey from the station in 1854. It was rebuilt in 1905 and is today, one of the biggest stations in India.

## **New requirements**

Throughout India, stations were located according to population distribution, industrial centres, and terrain. The general opinion was that there was no need for elaborate structures, as it was an unnecessary expense. This attitude changed in 1854 after Madras approved the classification of stations into four categories. While those used by Europeans fell into the first and second class, towns with larger traveller populations were placed under the third-class category. Smaller stations with a low passenger footfall qualified as fourth class.

These mostly had provisions for shelter from the weather. Third-class stations were scarcely better with booking offices made slightly larger for any passing European travellers, and an inadequate number of ticket offices. Significant stations such as Jamalpur and Cawnpore (present-day Kanpur) often saw large crowds fighting to purchase tickets from one clerk as there were not enough third-class ticket windows. By 1864, a Government of India circular acknowledged the need for better facilities, such as lavatories and refreshment rooms.